

Body is made of
springy jelly inside
a layer of skin

A ring of muscle
squeezes the body
during swimming

Small red lumps on
the body are clusters
of stinging cells

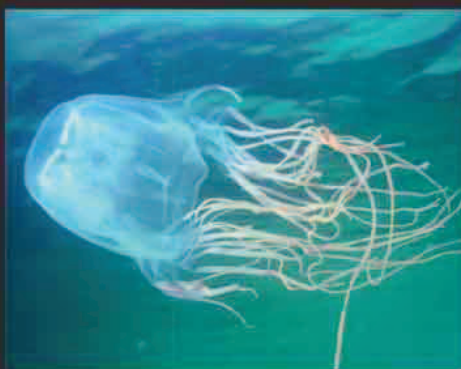
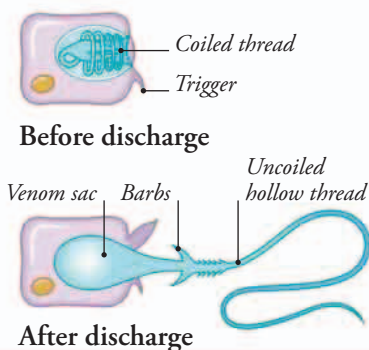
Eight long tentacles
are armed with
stings to catch prey

WOW!

The mauve stinger's body
is only 4 in (10 cm) wide,
but its stinging tentacles
can trail beneath it
for more than
33 ft (10 m).

STINGING CELLS

Jellyfish, anemones, and other cnidarians are armed with tiny stinging cells. Each cell contains a barbed, venomous harpoon. When it is triggered—usually by touch—the harpoon shoots out and pierces the skin of an enemy or prey, injecting its venom. Each cell is microscopic, but a single jellyfish may have thousands or even millions of them on its long stinging tentacles. The effect of these massed stings on human victims can be incredibly painful, and even lethal.



TROPICAL KILLER

Also known as sea wasps, box jellyfish are considered to be among the deadliest animals in the ocean. They live in the tropical coral seas around Australia and Indonesia. The biggest of these is only the size of a basketball, but its tentacles are armed with more than 30 million stings.

SEA ANEMONES

They may look harmless, but sea anemones are efficient predators. They feed by trapping tiny drifting animals and other food particles with their stinging tentacles. Many, such as these jewel anemones, look like colorful flowers, while others such as the snakelocks anemones resemble writhing clusters of worms. They also vary in size, from about 0.5 in (1.5 cm) to 3 ft (1 m) in diameter.



PERFECT PARTNERS

Although sea anemones can catch and kill prey with their stinging cells, the clownfish of tropical coral seas are immune to their venom; mucus on the fish's skin stops it from being stung. The clownfish live in partnership with certain species of anemone and shelter among their tentacles, which protects them from predators. In return, the clownfish eat the small animals that might harm the anemones.